GUIDE 02

Aging Faster Than You Should

Why you may look older than you feel, and the few things worth fixing first.

The Kira Method

5 sneaky things that can make you look older · 2 blood tests worth asking your doctor about · A simple routine to start with

READ THIS FIRST

Looking older than you feel is common. Most of it is not fate.

Skin and body age in two ways. One is time and genes. You cannot change that. The other comes from what happens to you year after year: sun, sleep, smoking, and how you treat your skin. That second part is where this guide lives.

We will not sell you a miracle cream. Here is what you get:

1. **5 sneaky things** that can make you look older, with the proof for each (Chapter 1).
2. **2 blood tests** worth asking your doctor about when you feel tired and look worn (Chapter 2).
3. **A simple routine** to start with, using few products (Chapter 3).

Please read: this is education, not medical advice

We are not doctors. Nothing here diagnoses or treats a condition. Every claim is tied to a source at the back, and we mark where the evidence is weak. Do not start supplements, prescription creams or new medicines without your doctor.

A promise about honesty

For each of the 5 things we tell you how strong the proof is: STRONG FAIR WEAK . That way you spend your time on the ones that matter most.

CHAPTER 1

5 sneaky things that can make you look older

1 Sun on ordinary days STRONG

Not beach days. Ordinary days: the walk to the car, the drive to work, lunch outside, the window seat. Dermatologists say most visible skin aging on the face comes from ultraviolet (UV) light. You will often see “about 80%” quoted. That figure is repeated a lot, mostly in skincare marketing, and some sources say 75%. So read it as “a big share,” not an exact number.

The American Academy of Dermatology (AAD) advises a **broad-spectrum, water-resistant sunscreen with SPF 30 or higher** on all skin that clothes do not cover, and reapplying about every 2 hours outdoors. UV still reaches you on cloudy days.

> **Good news**
>
> One small study (32 people, 52 weeks, 2016) found that daily broad-spectrum SPF 30 may visibly improve some existing sun damage, not only prevent new damage. It is a small study, so treat it as encouraging, not proven.

Do this: Make sunscreen the last step of your morning, like brushing teeth. Face, neck, chest, backs of hands. Keep one bottle in the car.

2 Short or broken sleep FAIR

In a study of 60 women ages 30 to 49, poor sleepers showed more signs of skin aging than good sleepers. That included more fine lines, uneven color, and less firmness. Their skin also recovered more slowly from stress (for example, redness after sun).

> **Honest note**
>
> That study was paid for by a cosmetics company, was small, and shows a **link**, not proof that bad sleep causes the changes. The result still fits what many studies find about sleep and health, so protecting sleep is a safe bet.

Do this: Aim for at least 7 hours a night (the recommendation of two major U.S. sleep groups for adults). If you wake at 3AM often, see our book *The 3AM Signal*.

3 Smoking STRONG

A University of Michigan study photographed the inner arms of 82 people ages 22 to 91 (skin the sun rarely touches). Smoking was the second-best predictor of fine wrinkling, right after age itself. That tells us tobacco affects the skin by itself, not only by making people squint.

Do this: If you smoke, a doctor can help you pick a method that works. In the U.S., 1-800-QUIT-NOW connects you with your state quitline.

4 A sugar-heavy way of eating WEAK

When sugar sticks to proteins in your body (a process called glycation), it can make them stiffer. That includes collagen, which keeps skin springy. This is real chemistry. But large human studies showing that cutting sugar makes faces look younger are missing. Many “sugar face” claims online are marketing.

Do this: Treat this as a bonus, not a main fix. Cutting back on added sugar is a good idea for other reasons (see *The Belly Fat Lie*). If your face changes too, enjoy it.

5 Harsh washing and no moisturizer FAIR

The AAD advises washing your face no more than twice a day (and after sweating), and choosing products labeled “fragrance-free,” “hypoallergenic” or “non-comedogenic.” A daily moisturizer helps hold water in the skin, which makes it look plumper and smoother.

Do this: One gentle cleanser. Lukewarm water, not hot. Moisturizer while your skin is still a little damp.

> **Honorable mention: stress**
>
> You will see “stress hormones break down your collagen” everywhere. The idea is plausible. But we did not find solid human studies proving it, and most of the pages saying it sell products. Stress is still worth managing for your sleep and health. We just will not put it in the top 5.

CHAPTER 2

2 blood tests worth asking your doctor about

If you are tired, your skin is dry, your hair is thinner, and your doctor said “you look fine,” there are two lab tests that are common to ask about. We are not saying you need them. We are saying they are reasonable questions.

> **Important**
>
> Only a doctor can order and read tests. A “normal” result means one thing is probably not the cause. A “not normal” result is not a diagnosis. Never start iron or thyroid pills on your own.

1 Thyroid test (TSH)

What it is: Your thyroid is a small gland in your neck. It sets how fast your body “runs.” The TSH test is the usual first check. Doctors often add a second test (free T4).

Why ask: An underactive thyroid can cause tiredness, dry skin, thinning hair, feeling cold, constipation, heavy or irregular periods, brain fog and low mood. Those are also common in perimenopause and stress, so it is easy to miss.

What experts say: The American Thyroid Association suggests adults start TSH testing at age 35 and repeat every 5 years if normal. Other expert groups say the evidence is not strong enough to screen everyone who has no symptoms. If you **do** have symptoms, asking is reasonable.

About the numbers: Labs use ranges such as about 0.4 to 4.0 or 4.5 mU/L. The range printed on your own report is the one to use. A result “in range” does not always mean you feel well.

2 Ferritin (your iron savings account)

What it is: Ferritin shows how much iron your body has stored. The basic blood count (hemoglobin) can look normal while your stores are low.

Why ask: Low iron is linked with tiredness and hair thinning, especially in women with heavy periods. Some studies connect low ferritin with diffuse hair loss in women, but the evidence is limited.

What to know: “Low” is debated. Some labs call under 30 ng/mL low. One review suggests considering treatment for women with unexplained tiredness when ferritin is under 50. This is for your doctor to decide, with your whole picture.

Safety: Do not take iron pills without a test. Too much iron can be harmful. Ask your doctor how long to take it and when to recheck.

How to ask (copy this)

“I have been tired and my hair and skin have changed. Could we check my thyroid (TSH) and my ferritin? Is there anything else you would check?”

One more routine test, just so you know

The American Diabetes Association advises blood sugar screening (A1C or fasting glucose) starting at age 35, or earlier if you have extra risk factors. It is not an “aging” test, but it is a standard one that many women skip.

CHAPTER 3

A simple routine to start with

Fewer products, used every day, beat a shelf of products used when you remember. Start here. Add more only if you want to.

When	Step	Why
Morning	1. Rinse with lukewarm water, or use a gentle cleanser. 2. Moisturizer. 3. **Sunscreen SPF 30+**, broad-spectrum. Face, neck, chest, hands.	Sun is the biggest thing you control.
Evening	1. Gentle cleanser. 2. (Optional) a retinol product. 3. Moisturizer.	Retinoids are the most studied "active" ingredient in dermatology.
Weekly	Look at your skin and moles in a mirror. Note any new or changing spot.	Catches problems early.

About retinol

- Over-the-counter retinol comes in strengths up to about 2%. Prescription versions (like tretinoin) are stronger.
- Start slow: **every other night**. Move to nightly only if there is no irritation.
- Use sunscreen every morning. Retinoids make skin more sensitive.
- **Not for use in pregnancy.** If you are pregnant, planning to be, or nursing, ask your doctor first.

The habits behind the routine

- **Sleep:** 7+ hours. Same wake time.
- **No tanning beds.** Ever.
- **Do not smoke.**
- **Strength training twice a week.** It supports your whole body as you age (see *The Belly Fat Lie*, Chapter 2).

See a dermatologist soon if a spot…

- is new, or changes in size, shape or color,
- has an uneven edge or more than one color,
- bleeds, itches, or does not heal in a few weeks.

Skin cancer found early is much easier to treat. Do not wait to see if it goes away.

YOUR 14-DAY START

Do these in order

Days	Do this
1	Take a photo of your face in daylight, no makeup. (It is for you, not for anyone else.) Buy SPF 30+ and a plain moisturizer if you do not have them.
2–5	Sunscreen every morning. Moisturizer morning and night. Nothing else.
6–8	Fix your wake-up time (7+ hours in bed). Check your face-product labels and drop what you do not need.
9–12	(Optional) Add retinol every other night.
13	Fill in the “Doctor’s Brief” from your bonus pack. Note if you are tired, cold, losing hair, or have heavy periods.
14	Take a second photo. Compare. Book the doctor visit if you are still tired.

My notes

Skin feels…	
Sunscreen days (of 14)	
Questions for my doctor	

The bottom line

You cannot stop time. You can slow the part that is not time: sun, short sleep, smoking, and rough habits. And if you feel worn out, ask about the basics a doctor can check.

SOURCES

Where this comes from

We searched in October 2026. Labels: **A** = official or peer-reviewed source. **B** = health system or news report of research. **C** = commercial or consumer media (rule of thumb only). Links may change.

1. **Sun and skin aging; sunscreen advice.** American Academy of Dermatology: "How to prevent premature skin aging" (aad.org/news/prevent-premature-skin-aging); broad-spectrum SPF 30+, water resistant, reapply about every 2 hours. The "about 80%" figure traces to Flament et al. ("Effect of the sun on visible signs of aging in Caucasian skin"); widely repeated in brand material; some sources say 75%. [A for AAD advice; B/C for the percentage]
2. **Daily sunscreen and existing sun damage.** *Dermatologic Surgery*, 2016, 32 participants, 52 weeks. Small study. [A, small]
3. **Sleep and skin aging.** Oyetakin-White P. et al., *Clinical and Experimental Dermatology*, 2015: 60 women ages 30–49. Funded by Estée Lauder. Correlation. [A, with caveats]
4. **Smoking and wrinkling.** Archives of Dermatology, 2007, University of Michigan: 82 people ages 22–91, inner upper arm. [A]
5. **Sugar and skin.** Glycation is documented chemistry. Human evidence that cutting sugar changes visible aging is limited (2026 fact-check summary of a review). [B, weak]
6. **Washing and moisturizer.** American Academy of Dermatology skin-care guidance (via Dermatology Times and aad.org). [A/B]
7. **Retinoids.** Dermatology review summaries; start every other night; avoid in pregnancy. [B]
8. **Thyroid.** American Thyroid Association (thyroid.org): TSH from age 35, repeat every 5 years; overlap of symptoms with normal-thyroid people. Reference range varies by lab (about 0.4–4.0/4.5 mU/L). [A/B]
9. **Ferritin.** Clinical review PMC10727104 and summaries: ferritin is considered the most reliable test for iron deficiency; thresholds debated (30 vs 50 ng/mL). Hair-loss link has limited evidence. [A/B]
10. **Diabetes screening.** American Diabetes Association Standards of Care: screen from age 35 (earlier with risk factors); A1C 5.7–6.4% prediabetes (Mayo Clinic). [A]
11. **Sleep amount.** American Academy of Sleep Medicine and Sleep Research Society: at least 7 hours for adults 18–60. [A]

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